Rico Qi

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Education

University of Washington Expected Graduation: June 2027
MS in Computer Science, BS in Mathematics

- GPA: 3.9/4.0
- **Relevant Coursework:** Reinforcement Learning, Deep Learning, Natural Language Processing, Algorithms and Data Structures, Mathematical Analysis, Linear Algebra, Probabilistic Robotics.
- **Awards**: 2x ICPC Worlds qualifier (2024, 2026); Pacific Northwest 2025 Champion; 10th at North America 2026.

Experience

Machine Learning Intern, Autopilot *Palo Alto, CA*
Tesla *May 2025 - Sep 2025*

- Worked under the Foundation Models team; Trained a model that achieved SOTA in the company for handling emergency vehicles.
- Deployed my model to the June Robotaxi Launch at Austin.
- Helped create benchmarks to evaluate models on emergency vehicle handling abilities.
- Merged my model's capabilities into the main end-to-end model through RL.
- Contributed to scaling up the end-to-end architecture by adding a cotraining task.
- **Skills**: Pretraining, Posttraining, RL, Large-Model Training, Iterating on Training Recipe.

Research Assistant *Seattle, WA*
University of Washington *Jan 2025 - Present*

- Researching robot learning under Professor Abhishek Gupta (WEIRD Lab).
- See "Papers" section.
- **Skills**: Robotics, ML, Real-world RL, SAC, Diffusion and Flows, Generalist VLA, Post-training, Sim2real, SFT, DAgger.

Software Engineer Intern *San Mateo, CA*
Snowflake *July 2024 - Oct 2024*

- Led an effort to create and develop Snowflake's tutorial page for its web app.
- Deployed 8 tutorials, covering content such as website structure, SQL, and optimization.
- Worked with billing, product, design, and database teams on various miscellaneous tasks.

Papers

Q-OIL: Optimistic Exploration in Learning from Human Interventions *Feb 2025 - Sep 2025*

- We design an RL algorithm that use interventions as optimism signals for exploration.
- We attains 10-50% higher success rate with 30% less interventions against SOTA baselines, across real tasks and users.
- Accepted to CoRL 2026.

Improving Generalist Policies with Simulation Post-Training *May 2026 - Present*

- We design a VLA post-training pipeline that requires no human teleoperation effort, using simulation.
- We successfully improve pi-0.5 from 5% to 60% success rate on long-horizon precision tasks, beating baselines that require human demos.
- Accepted to CoRL 2026, Sim2Real2Field workshop.

Skills

Languages: Python, C++, Java.